



Update on the COM-B model and its application to intervention development



Topics

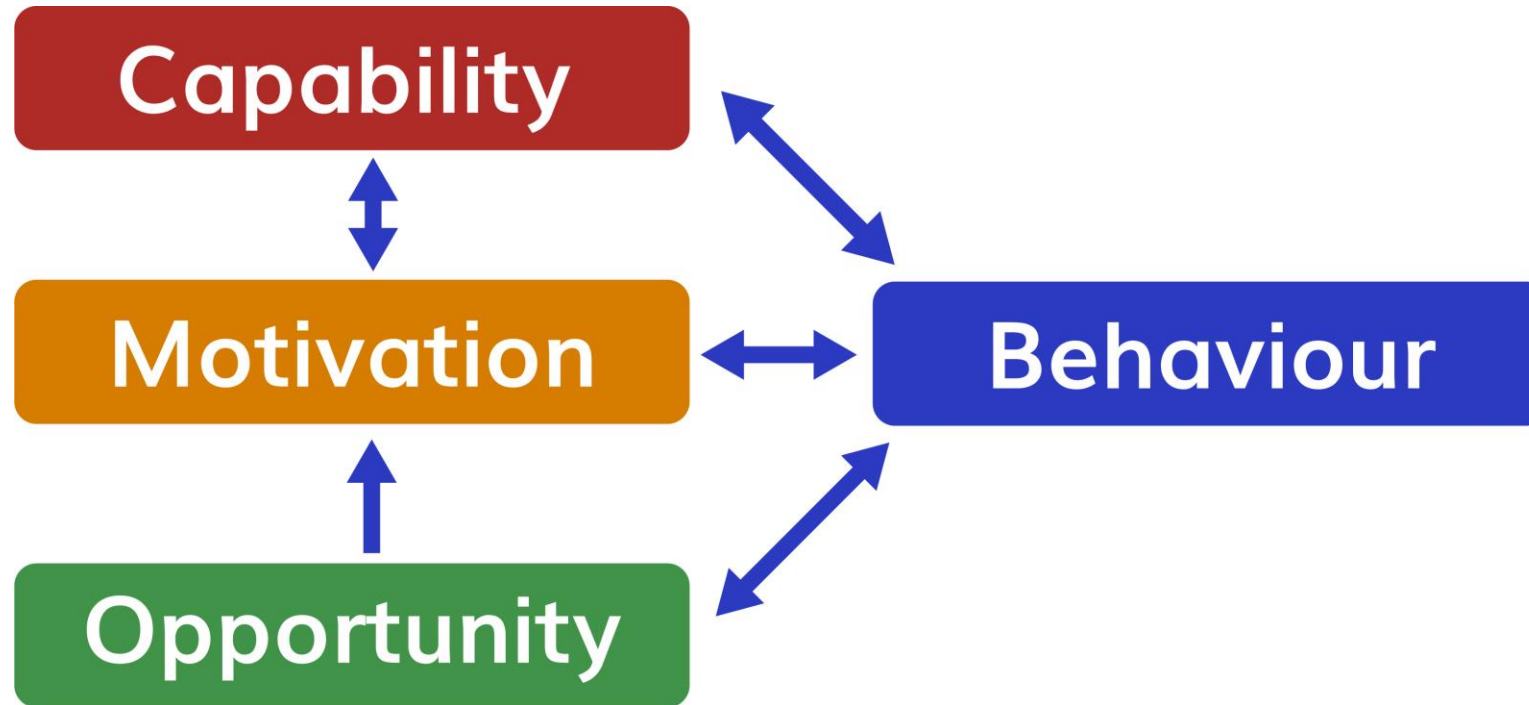
- Brief overview of COM-B
- Summary of draft COM-B updates
- Application to intervention development using the CACTIS (COM-B Assessment To Intervention Strategy) tool

What does COM-B aim to do?

Understand what to target in order to influence a given behaviour, such as:

- Signing up to a behavioural support programme
- Stopping smoking tobacco
- Cutting down on alcohol consumption
- Increasing level of physical activity
- Improving diet
- ...

The COM-B model of behaviour

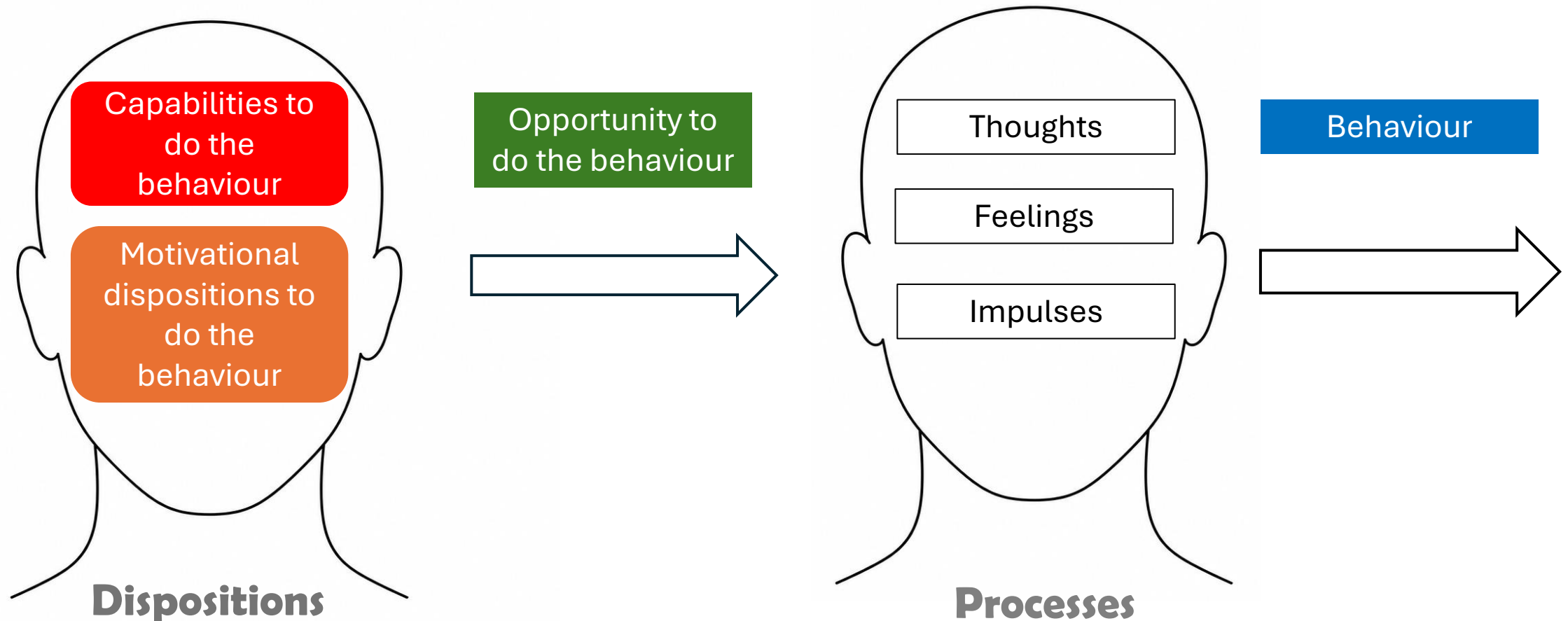


<https://www.com-b.org>

Summary of COM-B updates

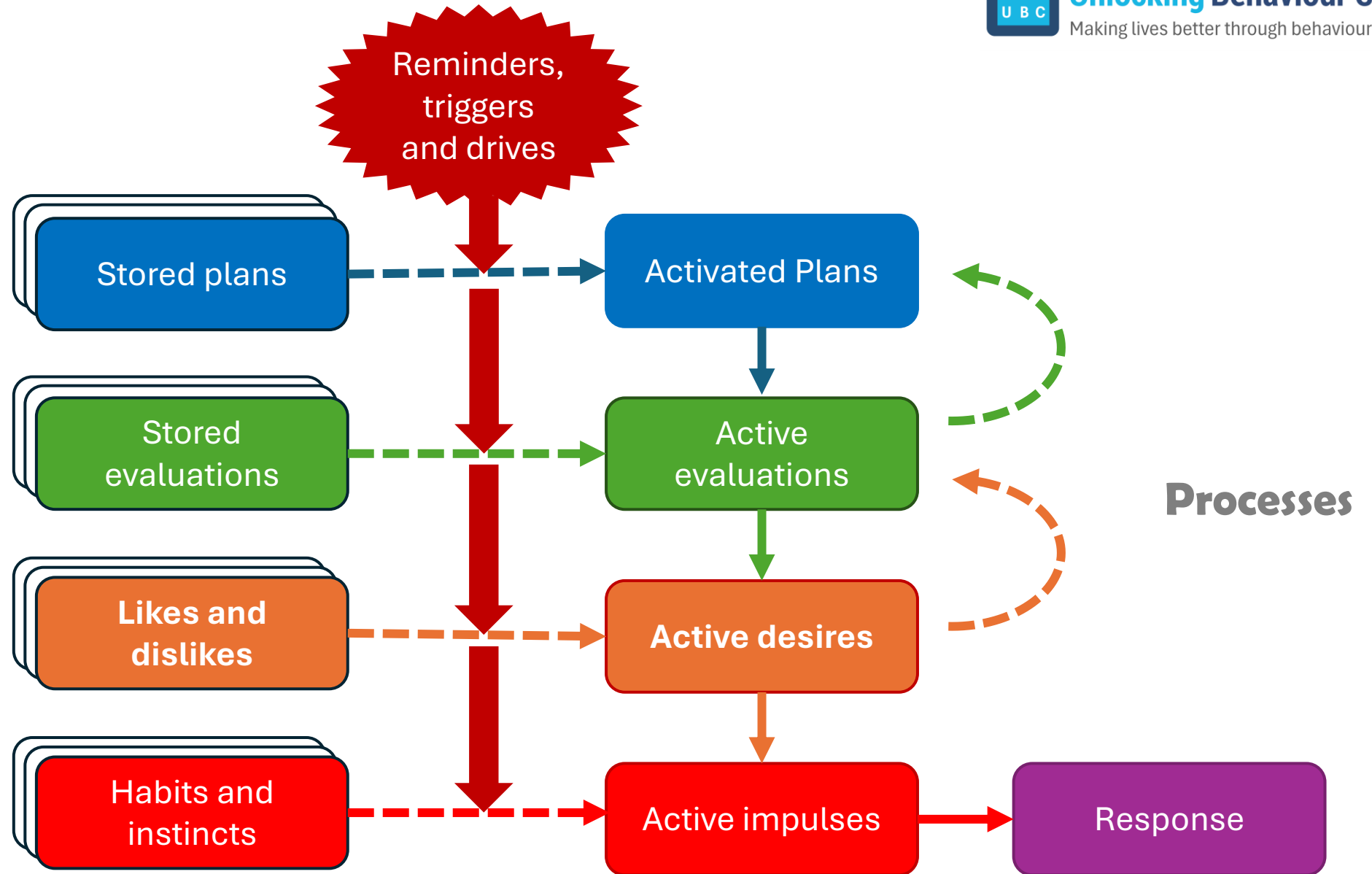
1. Differentiation of **'core' versus 'aggregate'** COM-B model
2. Clarification and **expansion of definitions** of COM-B components
3. Detailing **specific COM-B targets**
4. Linking COM-B components and targets to **'ontology' classes**
5. Clarification of **causal relations** between COM-B components

The COM-B model of behaviour





Dispositions



Core versus aggregate COM-B

Core

1. At any given moment, for a given person, what is the **likelihood** of the behaviour occurring?
2. Momentary capability, opportunity set the boundaries for the behaviour
3. Momentary motivation determines the choice among competing behaviours

Aggregate

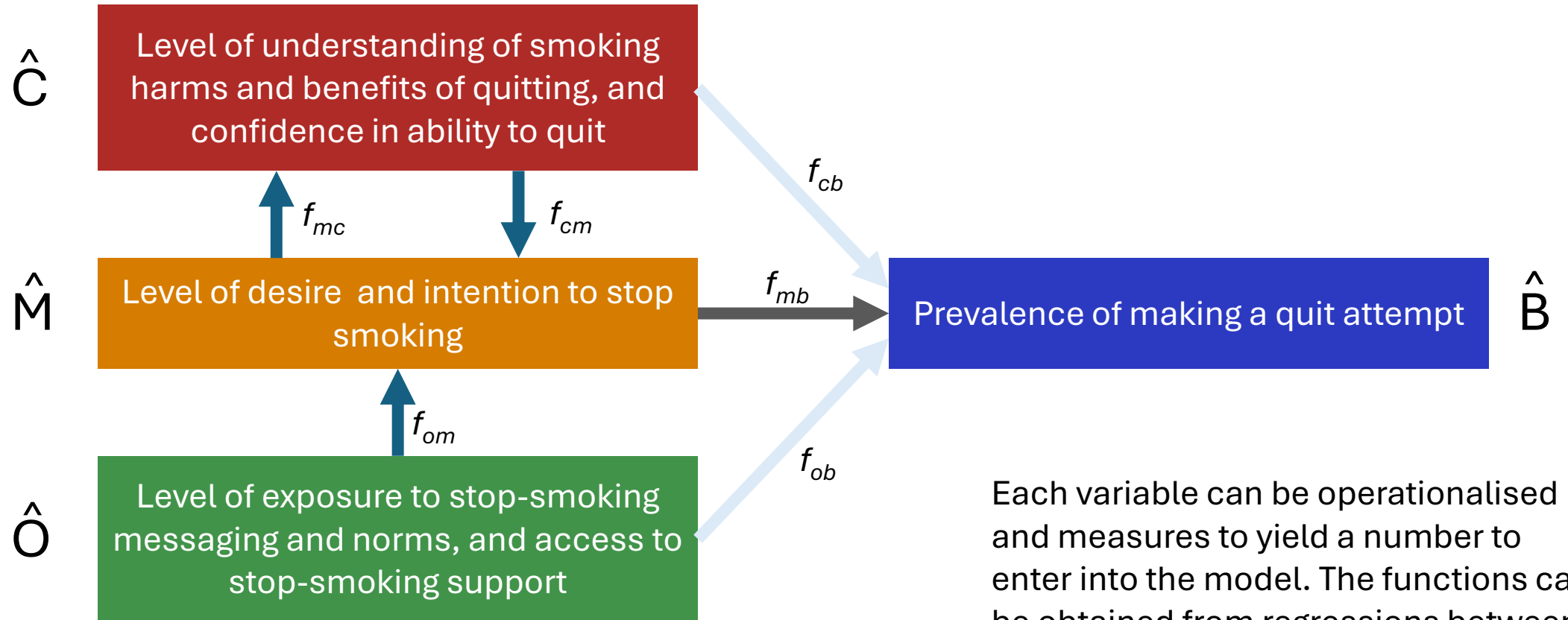
1. Over a period of time in a group or population, what is the expected **prevalence, incidence, frequency or amount** of the behaviour
2. Statistics about the **level** of capability, opportunity and motivation combine statistically to make the estimation

What aggregate COM-B provides

Clearer guidance on what needs to be specified in terms of the behavioural goal and the COM-B targets:

1. What **statistics** representing the behavioural goal, and the capability, opportunity and motivational influences?
2. What **quantitative relationships** between the influences and the behavioural goal?
3. More precise and clearly specified input to population- or group-level models of behaviour

Example: Prevalence of attempts to stop smoking of adult tobacco smokers in England in e.g., November 2025



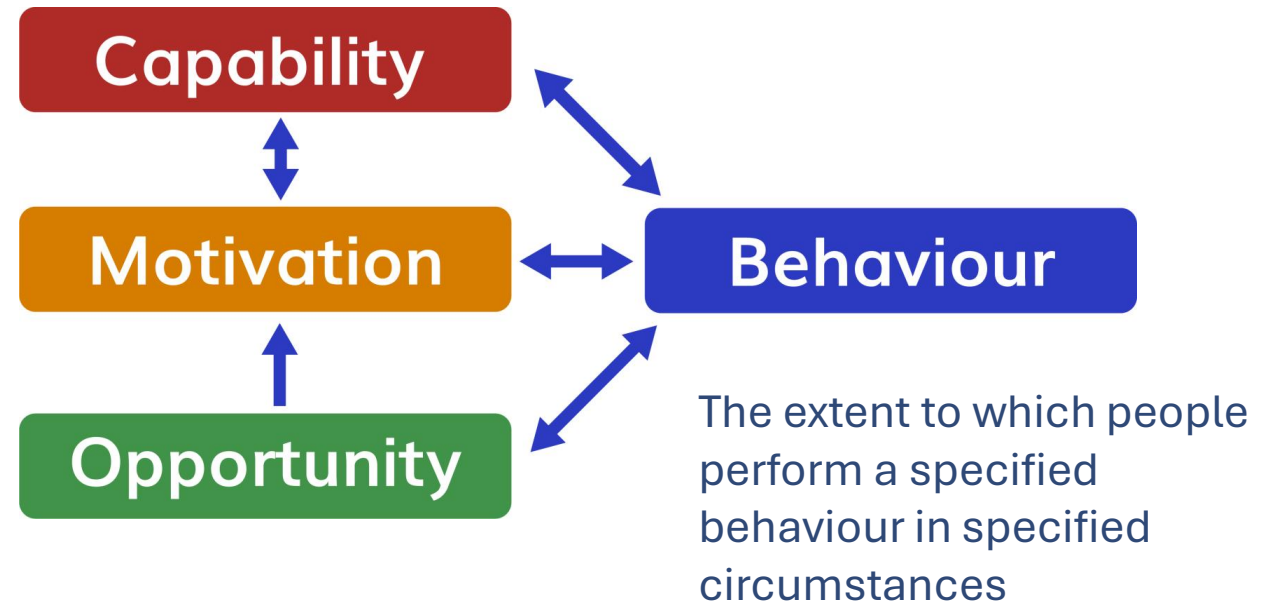
Each variable can be operationalised and measures to yield a number to enter into the model. The functions can be obtained from regressions between the variables.

Definitions of aggregate COM-B components

The degree to which people's abilities meet the requirements of, or support, a specified behaviour in specified circumstances

The degree to which people are motivated to perform a specified behaviour in specified circumstances

The degree to which people's environment enables or supports a specified behaviour in specified circumstances



COM-B targets: Capability

How **aware** are they of the behaviour?

How well do they **understand how** to do the behaviour?

How well do they **understand the reasons for** doing the behaviour?

How far do they have the **mental skills** needed to do the behaviour?

How far do they have the **self-control or resilience** needed for the behaviour?

How far do they have the **physical strength, stamina, flexibility and sensory abilities** needed for the behaviour?

How far do they have the **physical skills** needed for the behaviour?

How far do they have the **interpersonal skills** needed for the behaviour?

COM-B targets: Opportunity

How far is the behaviour considered **acceptable or desirable** in their social environment?

How **common and visible** is the behaviour in their social environment?

How far are there clear **social rules or expectations** (e.g., laws or regulations) about the behaviour?

How much **support** do they have for the behaviour in their social environment?

How far are they exposed to **prompts or reminders** to do the behaviour?

How easily can they **afford** to do the behaviour financially?

How far do they have access to **appropriate resources or equipment** for the behaviour?

How far do they have enough **time** to do the behaviour?

How easily can they access **spaces or facilities** to do the behaviour?

COM-B targets: Motivation

How **worthwhile** do they think the behaviour is relative to any downsides?

How far do they expect the behaviour to **make them feel good**?

How far do they expect the behaviour to **stop them feeling bad**?

How **confident** are they that they can do the behaviour?

How far is the behaviour being affected by **emotions or urges**?

How well does the behaviour fit with their **sense of who they are**?

How far have they set a strong **intention** to do the behaviour?

How strong a **priority** is the behaviour for them?

How **automatic** is the behaviour?

How far do they feel they have **agency** to do the behaviour?

Questions and discussion